Unknown Number

(Unknown Messages)

An interactive mystery game built inside an early-2000s desktop OS. Featuring early wireframe comparisons, player research, branching story trees, and visual design systems.

By Yves ▪ Publish Date: October 15, 2026

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1. The Idea Behind the Game

"Unknown Number" is a mystery game played entirely inside a retro early-2000s computer desktop. Created by Yves, the story starts when you receive a message in the middle of the night from a number you do not know. The sender calls himself Dan. He is convinced he is messaging Lia—a friend who disappeared years ago. Every choice you make either draws you deeper into the past or cuts the conversation short.

> THE PREMISE
> At 3:42 AM, a notification pops up on your screen from an unsaved number. Dan is desperate, confused, and looking for answers. As you reply, you piece together who he is, what happened between them, and why your recycled phone number led him to you.

1.1 What We Set Out to Build

- **Nostalgic 2000s Chat Feel:** Inspired by classic messengers like MSN and games like *Emily is Away*, complete with vintage window borders, taskbar buttons, sound chimes, and buddy lists right in your browser.
- **Choices That Actually Matter:** A branching story tree with 17 distinct dialogue points and 5 unique endings—from hanging up immediately to digging through old archives or meeting Dan at the lake pier.
- **A Playable Desktop:** Instead of reading text in a static box, you can drag windows around, pan through an interactive timeline map, collect pixel badges, and tweak settings from the bottom taskbar.

1.2 The Main Landing Page

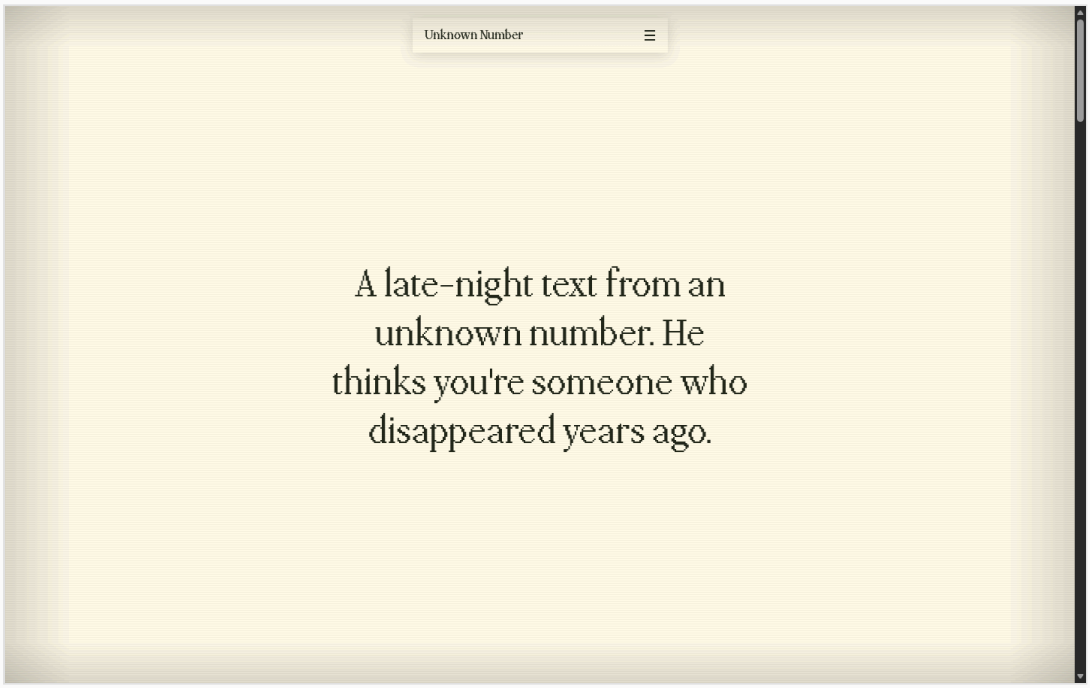


Figure 1.1: The main landing page — Warm vintage paper aesthetic with an opening letter that drops down as you scroll.

2. Player Research & What People Want

Before writing the dialogue or coding windows, I talked with fellow students aged 19–24 who regularly play story-driven games, indie mysteries, and visual novels. I wanted to see what keeps people hooked, and what usually frustrates them in choice-based games.

2.1 Player Profiles

From these conversations and playtests, three distinct player types stood out:



Alya Pratama (21)

THE STORY DETECTIVE

PLAYER PROFILE 01

> *"If a story offers choices, I want those choices to matter. I love peeling back layers of a mystery until the uncomfortable truth finally clicks."*

ABOUT HER

Studies: Media Communications

Location: Jakarta, Indonesia

Games She Plays: *Her Story*, *Sara Is Missing*, *Oxenfree*, mystery podcasts.

Play Style: Reads carefully, looks for hidden subtext, takes notes on timestamps.

WHAT SHE WANTS

- A story where small details and timestamps actually add up.
- Believable character dialogue rather than artificial exposition.
- Psychological suspense that feels genuine and personal.

WHAT ANNOYS HER

- Fake choices that all loop back to the exact same response.
- Endings that feel random or disconnected from what she chose.

Says	Thinks	Does	Feels
"Wait, what happened between Dan and Lia five years ago at the lake?"	"Is Dan in denial, or is something else going on with this old number?"	Carefully checks response timestamps and looks over character names.	A chill when Dan brings up memories only Lia would know.



Rafi Nugraha (22)

THE RETRO AESTHETICS FAN

PLAYER PROFILE 02

> *"Modern websites are too sterile. Give me window chrome, mechanical clicks, CRT scanlines, and pixel design that feels like a vintage artifact."*

ABOUT HIM

Studies: Computer Science, 4th Year

Location: South Tangerang, Indonesia

Interests: Windows 2000, *Emily is Away*, mechanical keyboards, pixel art.

Play Style: Tests window dragging, clicks buttons to hear sound effects, looks at UI details.

WHAT HE WANTS

- Sharp retro corners and a consistent late-90s desktop feel.
- Tactile sound chimes for incoming and sent messages.
- A desktop interface that behaves like an actual computer.

WHAT ANNOYS HIM

- "Faux-retro" web games with modern rounded corners and vector icons.
- Browser visual novels that feel like plain flat web forms.



Clara Wijaya (19)

THE COMPLETIONIST

PLAYER PROFILE 03

> *"I love visual novels, but I get super stressed if I can't see the branching tree or if I accidentally lock myself out of secret endings."*

ABOUT HER

Studies: Visual Communication Design

Location: Surabaya / Jakarta, Indonesia

Interests: Cozy mysteries, narrative games, badge collecting, Steam achievements.

Play Style: Plays during study breaks; driven to discover every possible path.

WHAT SHE WANTS

- A visual map showing story branches and unexplored paths.
- Collectible badges that reward trying different choices.
- A quick, clean reset button to restart without refreshing the page.

WHAT ANNOYS HER

- Being forced to sit through long intro text when restarting a run.
- Secret endings with zero hints or confusing unlock steps.

2.2 What Players Wanted & How We Built It

Here is how player feedback shaped the features we developed for the game:

Player Type	What They Want	What Annoys Them	How We Built It	How to Check It Works
Alya (Detective)	A mystery with real narrative consequences.	Choices that feel meaningless or lead to identical text.	17 story nodes leading to 5 distinct endings.	Every ending has its own unique outcome screen and badge.
Rafi (Retro Fan)	Authentic early-2000s desktop experience.	Sterile, modern web UI disguised as "retro".	Draggable windows, sharp 0px corners, sound chimes, and taskbar.	No rounded corners anywhere; sound effects play instantly on click.
Clara (Completionist)	Explore all endings without frustrating restarts.	Getting lost in story branches; losing save progress.	Pan/zoom Timeline Matrix with Fit View and a clean reset button.	Smooth timeline zoom (30% to 150%); badges stay saved across resets.

2.3 The Player Experience: Step-by-Step Walkthrough

Step	What the Player Feels	What They Do on Screen	What the Game Does in Response
1. Discovery	Intrigued by the mysterious late-night message teaser.	Scrolls down the landing page.	Words slide aside and the letter drops open to reveal Dan's text.
2. Conversation	Tension builds as Dan mistakes you for his missing friend Lia.	Opens the chat window and picks replies.	Typing indicator pauses before Dan's replies arrive with sound chimes.
3. Exploration	Wonders what would happen if they chose a different branch.	Opens the Timeline Matrix from the bottom taskbar.	Interactive map highlights explored paths and locked ending cards.
4. Completion	Satisfied after finding clues and unlocking all badges.	Opens the Badges window and resets for a new branch.	Unlocked badges stay lit while the chat resets cleanly for another run.

3. From Figma Sketches to the Playable Game

Here is how early design concepts in Figma evolved into the interactive desktop website you can play today:

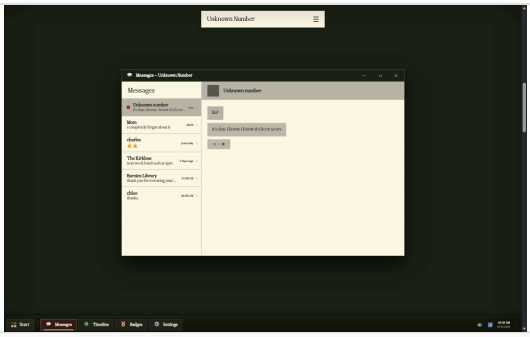
3.1 Messenger Window: Early Wireframe vs. Live Website

EARLY FIGMA WIREFRAME (CHAT & CONTACT LIST)



Figma draft: Early mockup showing the chat window alongside a multi-contact sidebar (Mom, Charles, Chloe, Library).

FINISHED WEBSITE (DRAGGABLE WINDOWS)



Finished Website: Fully draggable window with titlebar controls, typing indicator, sound chimes, and response buttons.

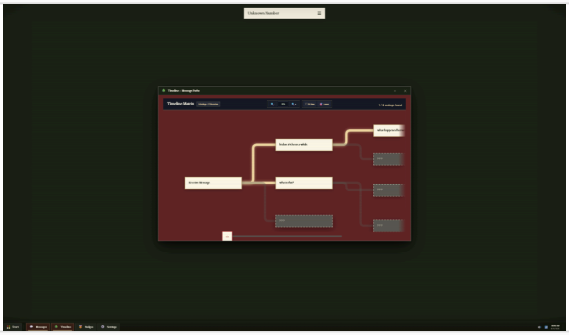
3.2 Timeline Map: Early Wireframe vs. Live Pan/Zoom Canvas

EARLY FIGMA WIREFRAME (STORY NODES CONCEPT)



Figma draft: Initial sketch of the branching story nodes with zoom slider placeholders.

FINISHED WEBSITE (INTERACTIVE TIMELINE MATRIX)



Finished Website: Interactive pan and zoom timeline canvas (30% to 150%) with Fit View and node tracking.

3.3 What Changed During Development

Feature	Early Figma Concept	Final Live Website	Why We Changed It
Window System	Static boxes fixed on the page.	Draggable desktop windows with focus layers.	Lets players move and arrange windows freely, just like a real computer.
Timeline Navigation	Static image diagram.	Interactive pan/zoom canvas with mouse and button drag.	Lets players explore all 17 story nodes without feeling cramped.
Chat Pacing	Messages appeared immediately.	Staggered typing indicator with sound effects.	Builds genuine suspense while waiting for Dan's next reply.

4. Wireframe vs. Website Comparison (Continued)

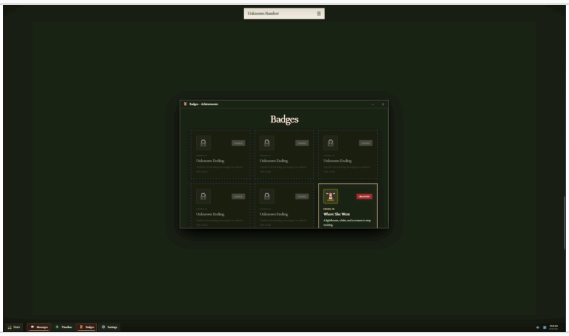
4.1 Achievement Badges: Figma Sketch vs. Live Grid

FIGMA WIREFRAME (FRAME 16 – BADGES SCHEMATIC)



Figma Wireframe: Early concept for the 2x3 badge window layout with placeholder blocks.

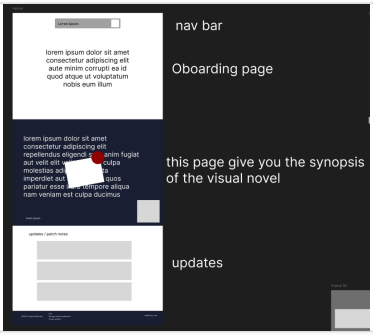
FINISHED WEBSITE (LIVE BADGE SHOWCASE)



Finished Website: Retro window displaying 6 achievement badges with unlockable pixel art.

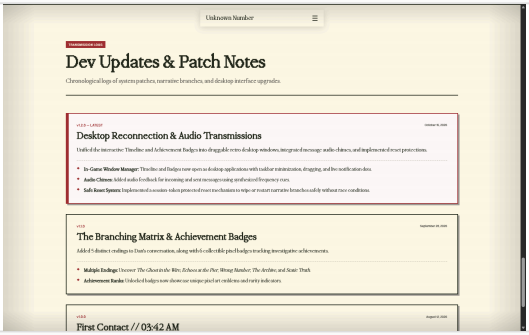
4.2 Home Page & Changelog: Figma Concept vs. Live Updates

FIGMA WIREFRAME (HOME ONBOARDING & UPDATES)



Figma draft: Vertical layout showing the top bar, intro letter, and changelog.

FINISHED WEBSITE (DEV UPDATES & PATCH NOTES)



Finished Website: High-contrast dev updates changelog with retro diamond bullet points and version chips.

4.3 Complete Branching Story Graph

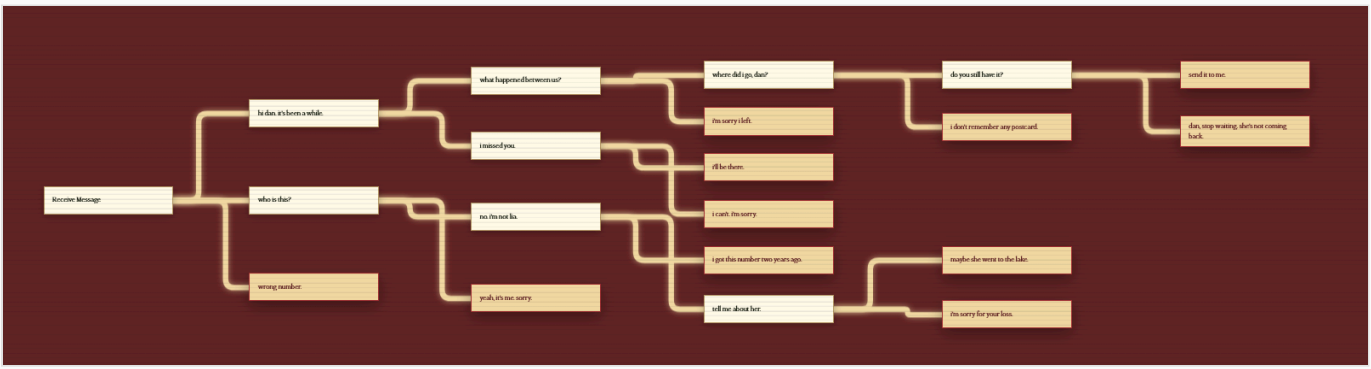


Figure 4.1: Complete Story Branching Tree – 17 story nodes leading to 5 different endings.

5. Development Roadmap & Future Story Updates

How the project came together and what's planned next for the multi-contact update:

MILESTONE 1 // COMPLETED

Core Story & Engine

- 17-Node branching story tree
- 5 Distinct story endings
- Typing indicator with realistic delays
- Responsive reply choices
- Scroll-scrubbing letter intro

MILESTONE 2 // COMPLETED

Desktop Window System

- Draggable window headers
- Click-to-focus window layers
- Bottom taskbar and tray buttons
- Sharp retro pixel styling
- 8-Color vintage palette

MILESTONE 3 // CURRENT BUILD

Timeline & Achievements

- Interactive pan/zoom Timeline Matrix
- Fit View and latest node buttons
- 6 Collectible achievement badges
- Sound chimes on send and receive
- Clean story resets from Settings

MILESTONE 4 // UPCOMING

Multi-Contact Stories

- Phone carrier recycled number notice
- Texts from Mom hearing house noises
- Charles fact-checking what happened
- Barnies Library overdue book clue
- Standalone About and Contact pages

5.1 Multi-Contact Dialogue Backlog

In the upcoming update, the chat sidebar expands with other contacts. Because Dan is an unknown number reaching out in the dead of night, your other contacts do not know him, giving players subtle clues and grounded worldbuilding:

Contact / Sender	Incoming Message	Story Purpose
Carrier Notice (SMS)	`[SYSTEM NOTICE]: Your number (reissued Aug 2026) was previously registered to another account. You may receive legacy routed SMS.`	Explains naturally why Dan reached your phone: the phone company reassigned Lia's old number to you.
Mom (03:45 AM)	`"Sweetheart, is that you walking around downstairs? I thought I heard the front gate latch."`	Adds real tension at home—while Dan is messaging you, Mom hears someone near the front gate.
Charles (03:44 AM)	`"Why at 3 AM?? Yeah, a girl vanished at the lake pier in 2021. Only found her bike. Why?"`	Lets you text a friend to verify what happened to Lia at the lake back in 2021.
Barnies Library	`"Reminder: Account under this number has 1 item overdue since Oct 2021: 'Regional Topography & Waterways, Vol. 2'."`	A subtle clue showing what Lia was researching right before she vanished.
Chloe (03:43 AM)	`"Are you still awake studying? Can I borrow your notes for 8 AM class, my brain is fried lol."`	Normal college homework banter that contrasts with the eerie mystery unfolding.

6. Badges & Sound Design

6.1 Collectible Achievement Badges

Six distinct badges reward players for exploring different story paths and finding secret endings:

Badge Name	Rarity	Icon	How to Unlock
First Transmission	COMMON	Envelope [✉]	Reply to Dan's opening text message at 3:42 AM.
Ghost In The Wire	RARE	Ghost [👻]	Pretend to be Lia and unlock Ending 1.
Night Watcher	COMMON	Lantern [🏮]	Agree to meet Dan by the old lakeside pier (Ending 2).
Wrong Number	COMMON	Phone [☎]	Cut off the conversation and tell him it is a wrong number (Ending 3).
Archivist	RARE	Floppy Disk [💾]	Ask about the old newspaper records and town archives (Ending 4).
Static Truth	SECRET	Antenna [📡]	Uncover the complete mystery and reach the final transmission (Ending 5).

6.2 Sound Effects & Audio Design

The game does not rely on bloated sound libraries. It uses lightweight audio files and browser sound synthesis:

- `760369__froey__message-receive.wav`: Plays a retro chime whenever Dan sends a new message.
- `760370__froey__message-sent.wav`: Plays a tactile click when you choose and send a reply.
- A sound toggle in the Settings window lets players mute audio at any time.

6.3 Clean Story Resets

When starting over from the Settings window, the game increments an internal session counter (`session++`). Any pending message timers from the previous run are immediately cancelled, so old dialogue never leaks into a fresh playthrough.

7. Visual Design & Retro Aesthetic

The look of *Unknown Number* is built on authentic early-2000s desktop nostalgia. Instead of just adding a pixel filter over a modern website, the layout behaves like a real vintage operating system.

7.1 Making It Feel Like an Old Computer

> **Core Design Rule:** The screen is meant to feel like an actual computer terminal from around 2001. Every window, button, and chat bubble has strictly square corners (0px border-radius), chunky borders, and draggable 28px titlebars.

7.2 Typography

STORY PROSE & DIALOGUE (--DISPLAY, --BODY)

PP Mondwest Regular

A pixelated serif font by Pangram Pangram used for dialogue logs, letters, and narrative text. It feels like reading an old diary entry on a vintage monitor.

SYSTEM UI & BADGES (--LABEL)

PP Neue Bit Bold

A punchy bitmap font used for window titlebars, buttons, timestamps, and badge tags.

NO GENERIC MODERN FONTS

Bespoke Retro Pair

We avoided generic modern web fonts like Inter or Playfair to keep the retro atmosphere consistent throughout the whole game.

7.3 Color Palette

Ivory Mist #FFFAE9 Primary Canvas & Parchment	**Soft Peach** #F2D9A4 Window Accent & Card Glow	**Tea Green** #D2E5C5 Success Badges & Safe Branch	**Brown Red** #A43032 Player Outbound Pin & Alert
Olive #828700 Late-Night Desktop Canvas	**Ash Mist** #BCB7A9 Cold Inbound Chat Bubbles	**Dark Soft Peach** #B49965 Bevels & Window Borders	**Dark Brown Red** #632526 Terminal Choice Hovers

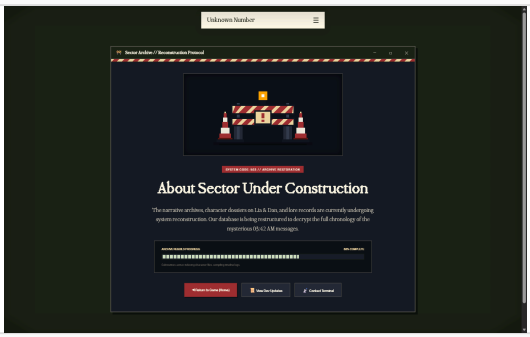
7.4 Subtle Tactile Details

- **Typing Dots:** A 3-dot animation shows Dan is composing a reply, giving players a moment of suspense before reading the next line.
- **Sound Feedback:** Instant chimes play when sending and receiving messages to give the feeling of an authentic messaging program.
- **Button Clicks:** Buttons depress by 1 pixel on click to feel like physical mechanical switches.

8. Standalone Under Construction Pages

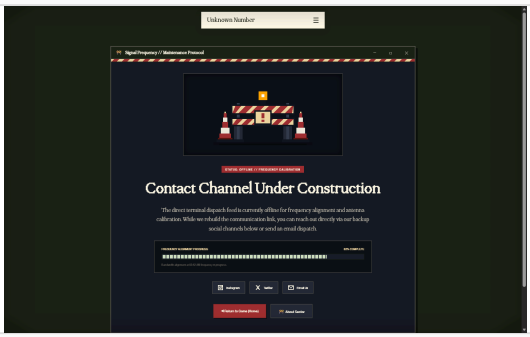
Instead of showing broken links or generic 404 pages when clicking secondary navigation, the About and Contact buttons open dedicated retro maintenance screens:

ABOUT.HTML — SECTOR UNDER MAINTENANCE



Pixel art traffic cones, hazard barrier, animated striped progress bar, and return dispatch link.

CONTACT.HTML — TRANSMISSION CALIBRATION



Live maintenance terminal with frequency calibration radar and social channel dispatches.

8.2 Design Consistency

Both secondary pages match the look and feel of the main game:

- **CRT Scanline Effect:** Both pages feature an ambient scanline overlay to keep the late-night monitor atmosphere.
- **Sound & Navigation:** Clicking the back button plays a mechanical click and returns you smoothly to the main desktop.
- **Pixel Art & Styling:** High-contrast hazard striping, tactile borders, and custom pixel fonts continue the retro computer theme.